pulled into the crowd for six. Everything is going our way, and 37 runs have come from nine balls.

Syed Mohammad, my partner at the crease, whips the next ball for four and, in what seems the blink of an eye, a match we had looked like losing is won with more than an over to spare. Our teammates run on to the field to celebrate and Virat Kohli, our captain, is the first person to reach me and hug me.

THAT ONLY HAPPENS IN THE MOVIES, screams another slogan on the giant screen.

I feel exhilarated, and join the post-match line to greet the opposition. Dale smiles as he shakes my hand. We've come a long way from our first-class debuts on the same day at SuperSport Park to this electric night in Bangalore, and he remains a great fast bowler, a great competitor and a great sportsman …

Not for the first time – and not for the last – I had been inspired by India, this great country that has provided me with so many opportunities and has become so important in my career.

It is the largest democracy in the world and the seventh-largest economy in the world. It is a vast and beautiful nation of more than 1.2 billion people, most of whom love cricket. And it is hard to believe that, not long ago, it was a country that many international cricketers used to dread; they would arrive on tour and complain about the hotels, the food, the training facilities and the transport, and could hardly wait to fly home.

Back in 1991, India was a few months away from defaulting on its international payment obligations; in a moment of profound crisis, the government secured an emergency loan of US$2.2 billion from the International Monetary Fund only by airlifting 67 tonnes of its national gold reserves to Europe as collateral. Things got worse. One of the vans transporting the gold broke down on its way to the airport.

A quarter of a century later, India is transformed. Economic growth